

Gather Around the Hearth

READY THE TABLE

- ☐ One Deckahedron per player, shuffled
- ☐ Blessing card deck – shuffled, face-down
- ☐ Wound card deck – shuffled, face-down; place a wound token beside it to distinguish the two decks
- ☐ GM Move Deck (Dramatic Action) – shuffled, at hand
- ☐ Scene sheet
- ☐ Token supply accessible at center of table: progress ✓, XP, Harm, Exhaustion, Shadow Points, Journey Points, green tokens, red tokens
- ☐ Blank index cards (for foes during combat)

GATHER AROUND THE HEARTH

1 • WHAT MAKES YOU FEEL AT HOME?

“What makes your character feel most at home, or what activity do they find the most comfort or competence in?”

Listen for vulnerability. Where does each character feel safe enough to be themselves, to let their guard down? This will shape the beginning of the story. Write down each player's answer.

PC	WHAT MAKES THEM FEEL AT HOME

2 • CHOOSE THE HEARTH

“This is a game where you all play together on the same team.

So, let's bring all these characters together. We're going to decide on something that exists in the world of our Touchstone List that all of these characters value. They value it so much that they are going to team up to defend it - maybe even with their lives.

We will call this thing "The Hearth".”

By consensus, choose one:

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Specific People | ☐ Food |
| ☐ Song | ☐ Environmental feature |
| ☐ Ritual or festival | ☐ Group activity |

THE HEARTH – READ ALOUD EXAMPLES

“The Hearth can be a specific person or people. Maybe each character shares a friendly uncle? The Hearth can be food. Do all these characters depend on the fruit of the quartzberry tree? The Hearth can be a song. Is the valley home of these characters always humming with the melodies of the wood elves? The Hearth can be an environmental feature. Does the village home of all these characters depend on the limestone spring for water? The Hearth can be a ritual or festival. On the equinox, must every tribe send a representative to seal the portal to the netherworld? The Hearth can be a group activity. No warrior may abandon the hunt until the beast is caught. Nor may they abandon each other.

Those are some examples, but the choice is up to you. What will be The Hearth of this band of adventurers?”

With follow up questions, make sure everyone agrees why this common thing bonds them together and why it makes them comrades that would risk their lives for each other.

RECORD THE HEARTH

Record on the GM Sheet.

An important aspect of The Hearth is that it must be something that the characters can be separated from. When the players are deciding on The Hearth, keep this in mind.

3 • WHY WOULD YOU RISK YOUR LIFE FOR THE HEARTH?

“Briefly, why would your character risk their life for The Hearth?”

Each player writes their answer on their character sheet. As they answer, move one **Shadow Point** onto the GM Sheet.

Move 1 Shadow Point to GM Sheet after each of the players' answers

THE GAME BEGINS

→ Paint the Opening Image, then consult the Scene Sheet and Chapter 1 procedures.